



Panasonic SDR-H20

When Beauty Meets Brains

"Drop dead gorgeous" comes to mind here. Although the SDR-H20 isn't as curvy as some of the other models, it has a unique shape—it's a little wide, but fits perfectly in the hand. Silver and black looks classy.

The menu layout is very simple, based around a single menu button and multi-function joystick that retains the intuitiveness. Even the menu button is conveniently located near the record button; in fact, none of the "essential to use while recording" buttons are located anywhere else but right under your thumb... in a word, brilliant! The zoom switch exudes a slick feel. There's a button on the viewfinder recess called "Power LCD Plus" that allows you to set the brightness of the LCD viewfinder in five stages. Our only gripe (yes... we always manage at least one!) was the bulky battery pack that sticks out of the back.

Since the SDR-H20 uses a massive 30 GB hard drive to store video, you won't need to be spending on media, or transferring video to your PC to clear up media space very often. Equally important, less moving parts makes for drastically reduced chances of a breakdown—anyone who's spent time with DV Tape based camcorders will agree.

As we'd expected, the SDR-H20's IS blew us away. Hand-shake is normal, but the minor jitter that is usually apparent at the



RATINGS OUT OF 10

Menu/OSD Usability	: 7.5
Ergonomics	: 8.5
IS effectiveness	: 8
Video Quality (Indoors)	: 7.5
Video Quality (Outdoors)	: 8
Photo Quality	: 6
Audio quality	: 7.5

long end of the zoom (32x optical at the long end) was absent—excellent results as far as the effectiveness of the IS system goes. The zoom works very well in tandem with the optical IS system that Panasonic employs.

We were very impressed with the image quality that the SDR-H20 was able to provide both indoors and outdoors. At a price of 29,990, the SDR-H20 is an excellent product. Good output quality, an excellent IS system—the best we've tested, and a feature rich offering that looks as good in the flesh as it goes the SDR-H20 should be your only choice if you have 30K to burn.

Specifications:

1 / 6-inch CCD image sensor (0.8 megapixel); LCD viewfinder 2.7-inches (123,000 pixels); Weight: 430 g



RATINGS OUT OF 10

Menu/OSD Usability	: 7
Ergonomics	: 7.5
IS effectiveness	: 6.5
Video Quality (Indoors)	: 6.5
Video Quality (Outdoors)	: 7/5
Photo Quality	: 5
Audio quality	: 7

Samsung VP-DC575Wi

Designer Looks, Killer Style

This Mini DVD-based camcorder looks the part of a super-model. A shape complemented with the right attire: dark and light grey tones never get stale, no matter how common they are. Completing the designer look is the build—solid to hold, in fact, better-built than its siblings. The button layout seemed unnecessarily complicated, though, and for the life of us we couldn't figure out the need for a Record button on the LCD viewfinder's outer frame. Once you get used to the button layout, however, the menu is very simple to get around. There's a 5-way joystick on the left that allows menu

navigation. The Zoom and Record buttons seemed very intuitively-placed, and feel excellent to use. So compact is the VP-DC575Wi that the zoom switch actually feels too close to your hand—a little cramped like the Canon DC51; of course, its forgivable since that model was much larger to begin with, and given the Samsungs compactness, we don't really have anything to complain about. There's a nicely-tapered, full-featured remote control unit for your convenience.

Samsung is known for brilliant LCDs, but we were a little disappointed with the viewfinder on the VP-DC575Wi.

The VP-DC575Wi allows still images to be saved to the memory card only—so your mini DVD will be used purely for video shooting. Indoors we noticed a little discoloration, especially around light pastel-like colours, which themselves had dappled sunlight falling on them—our window draperies to be exact. Although we found no casts, and although the IS system worked much better than those on the other two Samsung camcorders, we weren't satisfied with the amount of jitter that crept into our recordings. Once in bright sunlight, the jitter isn't very noticeable—this is a typical problem with nearly all consumer camcorders, which is why indoor testing is more important than outdoor testing.

At the long end of the zoom, noise was noticeable in all our indoor recordings—while this isn't apparent on the viewfinder during playback, the moment you connect your camcorder to any sort of large screen like a monitor or TV, it becomes glaring.

At Rs 24,500, the VP-DC575Wi is reasonably well-priced, and is suitable for a wide variety of tasks. Just don't buy it for a lot of indoor or after-dark shooting—you'll be sorely disappointed.

Specifications:

1 / 6-inch CCD sensor (1.0 megapixel); 2.7-inch widescreen LCD (112,000 pixels); Weight: 1.05 kg